DigiPick of the month

Well Receiving Transmission

This month's winner is
Ravneet Randhawa
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Kochi - 682 004

He wins **The Unix Programming Environment** by Brian W. Kernighan & Rob Pike Published by Pearson Education (Singapore) Pte. Ltd.

WIN!
Send in your entry and you could win a **Canon Pixma iP 1500** just by sharing an amusing picture with a tech angle to it. The picture should be shot by you, and should not have been published anywhere earlier. E-mail your picture with the subject **'DigiPick'** and your postal address **on or before 15th of this month** to **digipick@thinkdigit.com.** One prize-winning picture will be published each month.

FINALLY!

A Multi-Buttoned Mac Mouse

Apple users may possibly frown at this new, think-outside-the-box offering. It's just not Apple's style. It's a mouse with more than one button—four, to be precise.

And there's a 360-degree scroll ball, one that can scroll diagonally as well! Apple is calling it the 'Mighty Mouse'.

And mighty it is, compared to the ghastly hockey-puck mice that shipped with the colourful iMacs, and other stubbornly single-buttoned Apple mice.

For some it is Apple's finest mouse ever. Others call it a Trojan horse—one of several entry points into the Windows-user territory. Another indication of popularising Mac culture amongst Windows users.

Although a departure from the traditional one-button mouse, the Mighty Mouse looks similar to the other Apple models.

A major difference is the small scroll ball at the head of the mouse, which can move cursors diagonally, even up and down across display screens, and can be pressed to 'click' functions.

Since long, Apple has built added functionality to its OSes to accommodate multi-button mice. But there were no Apple mice to take advantage of this. We wonder why Apple took this long to bring mouse technology to the nineties!

Mighty Mouse, which connects via a USB port, will retail for $49 (Rs 2,130). It is PC-compatible, but cannot move the cursor diagonally on Windows.

So, is this the beginning of the end of the traditional difference between PCs and Macs? A multi-button mouse eliminates one of the important differences.

Recall that in May, Apple said it would cease using IBM processors in favour of Intel chips. With the new mouse, Apple is seeking to tap into the market for accessories.

This may be a leap forward for Mac users, but need Windows users pay any attention? Lara Luepke of ZDNet Australia sums it up best: "For Apple Mac OS Tiger users, the scrollwheeling Mighty Mouse is worth a look; for everyone else, better options are available."

"MIND THE BOMBS"

Outrage Over London Underground Terror Game

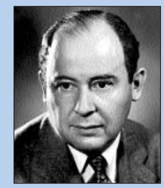
UK tabloid *The Sun* recently discovered an online game in which players have to stop bombs detonating on the London Underground system.

In a sick take on the "mind the gap" warning (referring to the gap between the train and platform) that sounds over the Underground every time

People Who Changed Computing

An All-Round Genius

Born in Hungary, John Luis von Neumann was a child prodigy. After his early education in Budapest, he moved to Zurich and later to Berlin, where he received degrees in chemical engineering and mathematics.



John von Neumann

Von Neumann was a brilliant mathematician and a staunch supporter of the stored-program concept.

His first association with computers was with the Harvard Mark I (ASCC) calculator. His greatest contribution to computing was the EDVAC in 1945—his single-handed creation. This is when the elements of the stored-program concept were introduced to the computing world.

The foundations of von Neumann's work were laid out in the "First Draft of a Report on the EDVAC" in 1945. It presented the first written description of the stored-program concept.

The report organised the computer system into four main parts: the Central Arithmetical unit, the Central Control unit, the Memory, and the Input/Output devices. This is popularly known as the 'von Neumann architecture'. Sounds familiar? It's this that has become the CPU-Memory-IO system that all computers use today!

The Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers (IEEE) continues to honour von Neumann through the annual IEEE John von Neumann Medal, "for outstanding achievements in computer-related science and technology."